language—Tamil—counts as an official language of another country, Singapore, whose etymological roots lie in the Sanskrit word ‘singha pura’ or lion city. South East Asia is to India what America is to Europe—a land once ruled from a distance, a magnet for trade and ultimately a destination for mass migration.

Suvarna Bhumi, or the land of gold (and the name of Thailand’s airport), receives short shrift in Indian history, obsessed as it is by events in north India. But for south India, and especially the eastern coast, its significance is enormous. In coastal Odisha, people still celebrate *Bali Jatra* or the voyage to Bali, a festival to commemorate historic merchant migrations to South East Asia. By the late 19th century, the Great Indian Migration Wave had firmly cast its web around the region that constitutes present-day Myanmar, Malaysia and Singapore, although in the latter two areas, migration over time became relatively more permanent in nature.

Between 1844 and 1910, the Malaya world received around 2,50,000 indentured Indians, mostly Tamilians and Telugus, to work in construction, transport lines and of course, plantations, though not necessarily sugar.[18] Oil palm plantations also attracted Indian workers. By the early 20th century, rubber had emerged as the most important product of the Malay economy and Indians would comprise over three-fourths of the workforce on the plantations that grew it. The living and working conditions of plantations were harsh and women and children were paid substantially lower wages than men. The unskilled workers worked on the fields while those who were slightly more skilled were involved in rubber tapping. Indians were preferred over the Chinese, who worked in the tin-mining sector, as their reservation wage was much lower. They were also preferred over the Javanese in Dutch-ruled Indonesia because British India provided simple negotiation-free access to labour.

A major migration wave occurred in the first three decades of the 20th century, by when indenture had given way to the *kangani* system of headman-mediated migration and then from the late 1920s to unassisted and more permanent migration. Another migration stream was towards the services sector. From north India, especially Punjab, people were recruited